

over the screen. One box contains all the usual tools—crop, zoom, filter, resize, perspectives, fill, draw, paintbrushes, etc.; another has a list of layers, paths, and colour channels. An image opens in a new window, so with the potential of having dozens of open windows and boxes, the higher the resolution the better. The GIMP is not only an image editor, but also a full-fledged drawing and painting program. It offers a wide spectrum of features like a full set of painting tools, anti-aliasing (the technique of minimising jagged or blocky patterns), full alpha channel support, and transparencies and layering. A cool transformation tool is rotation, which allows you to rotate an image to any scale or angle. The usual image formats are supported.

Once an image is loaded, right-clicking on it brings up a menu offering many tools and special effects. There's layer control and a full spectrum of filters for adding distortions such as engrave, emboss, scratches, etc., artistic tools such as canvases, oil painting, and many more. Bump mapping is supported. (This is a computer graphics technique where at each pixel, a perturbation to the surface normal of the object being rendered is looked at in a height map and applied before the illumination calculation is done; the result is a richer, more detailed surface representation that more closely resembles the details inherent in the natural world. Also supported is control of lighting effects. You basically have full control over all effects. Animation and video editing tools are also included.

The GIMP is definitely not aimed at beginners, and one is advised to read the help files (which are not very detailed) and the user manuals before jumping right in, so as to avoid being overwhelmed by the sheer power of this software.

**Note:** The GIMP requires the GTK 2 (GIMP Toolkit) and above runtime environment to run. Also, when uninstalling The GIMP, remove The GIMP before the runtime environment, otherwise your system will always assume that The GIMP is the default program for all images.